

Germany



An economic giant at the heart of Europe and one of the main supporters of the European Union.

400s BCE Germanic peoples from southern Scandinavia spread south into Germany, displacing the native Celts and occupying the whole country from the Rhine across to the Danube by c.360 CE.

9 CE The extension of the Roman Empire east of the Rhine is thwarted by a Germanic tribe, the Cherusci, under the leadership of Arminius at the battle of Teutoburgerwald. Roman rule over those tribes living west of the Rhine had already been accomplished by Julius Caesar in 56 BCE. From then on, Romans make no serious attempts to conquer the Germans again, although they do send punitive expeditions across the Rhine against troublesome tribes.

74 CE Romans begin annexation of Agri Decumates, the triangle of land between the Rhine and Danube rivers, and fortify its frontier with the Germans along the Roman Limes. They hold this southwestern part of Germany until 260.

200s German tribes merge to form powerful confederations, notably the Frankish confederacy.

250s Franks, Burgundians, Alemanni, and other German tribes begin to raid the Roman Empire.

370s The westward movement of the Huns causes many Germanic tribes to cross the Rhine into the Roman Empire. By the time the Roman Empire in the west finally collapses in 476, the powerful Frankish kingdom in the west and the Burgundian kingdom in the southwest of Germany are established.

561 Franks rule most of central, western, and southern Germany and steadily expand their realm into a vast empire.

800 The Frankish Empire reaches its apogee when Charlemagne is crowned Emperor of the West by Pope Leo III. However, the empire does not survive for long after Charlemagne's death in 814.

Civil war breaks out in 827 between his sons, and continues until the empire is divided into three parts: the German-speaking lands of East Francia are separated from what later becomes France in the Partition of Verdun in 843.

911 Duke Conrad, successor to Louis the Child, the last of the German Carolingians, is elected the first Saxon king of the Germans.

915 Magyars raid Germany, although they are eventually heavily defeated at Lechfeld in 955. At the same time, Vikings from Scandinavia raid the north coasts and sail up the rivers searching for plunder.

936 Otto I becomes king of the Saxon dynasty and begins to establish a powerful Saxon kingdom, defeating the independent German dukes of south Germany and fighting Magyar and Viking raiders. His kingdom includes most of western Germany and the Low Countries, although expansion eastward along the Baltic is only temporary, the lands being lost again in 982.

962 Otto I is crowned Holy Roman Emperor by the pope, thus making the German kings emperors of much of western Europe.

973 After the death of Otto, his successors continue to expand the Holy Roman Empire south and east to include the whole of Germany, the Low Countries, Austria, Switzerland, northern Italy, and southeast France. The German emperors have control over ecclesiastical appointments of bishops, abbots, and others, and grant lands as fiefs to these churchmen for them to administer, thus retaining control as the lands pass back to the crown on the death of the celibate churchmen. This system works as long as the emperor can keep control over the ecclesiastical appointments and acts as a balance against the powerful landholdings of the hereditary nobility.

1056 On the death of Henry III, his son Henry IV becomes king but because he is a minor, power is held by

a weak regency. The papacy takes the opportunity to reassert its authority over church appointments: the Investiture Contest (1075–1122) gives the papacy greatly enhanced power over appointments and thus weakens the emperor.

1152 Frederick I Barbarossa of the Hohenstaufen dynasty briefly revives German and Holy Roman imperial power at the expense of the papacy, while the crusading Teutonic Knights continue to expand the empire eastward along the Baltic coast. However, Frederick is challenged by powerful territorial princes, notably Henry the Lion of the Welf family, while his attempt to tighten imperial control in Italy is defeated by the Lombard League of northern cities at Legarno in 1176. Open warfare between the Guelphs, led by Henry the Lion and allies of the pope, and the Ghibellines, the imperial party, erupts. By the time of Frederick's death in 1190, the area covered by modern Germany is on the way to becoming a patchwork of nominally independent states.

1212 Frederick II attempts to consolidate imperial power, but is opposed by the papacy and the Italian cities. His reign ends in failure upon his death in 1250. An interregnum from 1254–73 sees great political instability as rivals fight it out for the imperial crown. In 1266 the Saxon dynasty is overthrown. However, many new German cities are established in Poland during the 13th century as the empire continues to expand to the east.

1241 Lübeck and Hamburg form a trading alliance that gives rise to the Hanseatic League, which during the later Middle Ages functions as an independent political power with its own armed forces.

1273 Count Rudolf of Habsburg establishes himself as King of the Germans and Holy Roman Emperor. This marks the start of the Habsburg dynasty's domination of Austria and Germany.

1325 The Wittelsbach family gains the upper hand over the Habsburgs, only to lose it to the Luxembourgs in 1346. Habsburg power is not restored until 1438, when Albert II is elected emperor.

1348–50 Black Death decimates German population.

1356 Emperor Charles IV issues the Golden Bull ending papal role in imperial elections. Seven electors now choose the emperor: the Duke of Saxony, the King of Bohemia, the Count Palatine of the Rhine, the Margrave of Brandenburg, and the bishops of Cologne, Mainz, and Trier.

1377–89 Habsburg, Wittelsbach, and Luxembourg princes combine to reduce the independence of the cities of southern Germany and the Rhineland.

1477 The Habsburg heir Maximilian I marries Mary of Burgundy, thus acquiring the Low Countries as well as Burgundy. When he becomes emperor in 1493, Habsburg power in Europe grows considerably as more lands are acquired by marriage and diplomacy.

1516 Charles V, grandson of Maximilian, acquires Spain and its vast European empire. On the death of Maximilian in 1519, he acquires the Habsburg lands and becomes Holy Roman Emperor. The Habsburgs now dominate Europe.



Trading power

This seal of the Hanseatic League dates from 1329. The League, an alliance of city guilds, established a powerful trading monopoly over most of northern Europe between the 13th and 17th centuries.

1517 The German theologian Martin Luther nails his 95 theses on the door of a Wittenberg church, challenging the established Catholic hierarchies and especially the practice of selling indulgences to raise funds. The debate he starts soon spreads around Germany.

1521 Luther is excommunicated by the pope and outlawed by the emperor at the Diet of Worms; these events mark the real start of the Protestant Reformation in Europe.

1524–26 Influenced by radical Protestant preachers and frustrated by economic hardship, Germany's lower classes rise up in a peasants' revolt. However, they are crushed by the army of Philip of Hesse, a Protestant who enjoys Luther's support, and 100,000 are slaughtered.

1530 German Protestants publish 28 articles of faith to prevent a split with the Catholic church; by now the princes of Saxony, Hesse, Brandenburg, and Brunswick are Lutherans as the Reformation spreads throughout northern Germany; most of southern Germany remains Catholic. Warfare between the emperor and Protestant states is common.

1534 Anabaptists seize Munster, prophesying the end of the world.

1547 Emperor Charles V defeats the Protestant Schmalkaldic League of Protestant princes at Mühlberg, but fails to stem the growing tide of Protestantism throughout Germany.

1555 Under the terms of the Peace of Augsburg, it is agreed by the Holy Roman Emperor that each German prince should be left free to impose the faith of his choice within his territories.

1556 Charles V abdicates: his vast empire is split in half, with the German

HOLY ROMAN EMPEROR (1122–90)

FREDERICK I BARBAROSSA

Frederick I Barbarossa was the German emperor who challenged papal authority and established German dominance over much of Europe. He was elected king in 1152 and immediately challenged the authority of the pope. Crowned emperor in 1155, he embarked on a series of six military campaigns against the Lombard leagues in northern Italy. In 1177, Barbarossa finally recognized Alexander III as the true pope, and was reconciled to him. Within the empire, Barbarossa struggled violently with Henry the Lion, duke of Bavaria, who was eventually stripped of his possessions. Barbarossa drowned crossing the Saleph River (in present-day Turkey) on the Third Crusade.

